

St. Paisios the Athonite on Fasting

1. Fast with Humility, Not Legalism

"Do not fast like the Pharisees, counting grams of oil or boasting about your discipline. Fast like the Publican, who beat his breast and said, 'God, be merciful to me, a sinner' (Lk. 18:13)."

"It's better to eat meat with humility than to judge others while eating lentils."

Spiritual Counsels Vol. 3: Spiritual Struggle

2. Start Small and Build Gradually

"If you've never fasted strictly, don't suddenly try to keep the full monastic rule. Begin by abstaining from meat on Wednesdays/Fridays, then add dairy, then oil—like training a muscle."

"A mother nursing a baby or a laborer doing heavy work should fast moderately, under their priest's guidance. God sees the effort, not just the plate."

Advice to laypeople (recorded in "Words of Life")

3. Fast with Purpose: Free the Soul, Not Just the Stomach

"Fasting without prayer is a diet. Fasting with prayer is a sword that cuts off passions."

"Use hunger pangs as a reminder: *'My soul hungers for God more than my belly for bread.'* Replace snacks with short prayers (e.g., *'Lord Jesus Christ, have mercy on me'*)."

Spiritual Counsels Vol. 1: With Pain and Love for Modern Man

4. Fast from More Than Food

"Abstain from gossip, screens, and idle talk during fasts. If your mouth avoids meat but bites your brother, you've fasted in vain."

"Give the money saved on fancy food to the poor. These turns fasting into almsgiving."

Oral teachings (compiled in "Passions and Virtues")

5. Never Judge Others' Fasting

"If you see someone 'breaking' a fast, don't assume they're lazy—they may be ill, pregnant, or under obedience to their confessor. Focus on your own plate."

"The devil loves when we monitor others' fasting more than our own hearts."

Epistles (Letters to spiritual children)

6. Prepare for Battles During Fasts

"Expect increased temptations—anger, pride, or cravings. The devil attacks hardest when we fast, but this is when grace grows stronger."

"If you fall (e.g., eat cheese by mistake), don't despair. Say, *'I'll be stricter next time,'* and continue. God honors the struggle, not perfection."

Spiritual Counsels Vol. 4: Family Life

7. Fast with Joy, Not Gloom

"Don't walk around with a mournful face to show others you're fasting (Mt. 6:16). Rejoice! Fasting is a feast for the soul."

"Simple fasting food (lentils, bread, olives) eaten with gratitude becomes sweeter than gourmet meals with complaint."

Sayings from pilgrims (Holy Monastery of St. Paisios)

8. End Fasts Gently

"After a long fast (e.g., Lent), don't gorge on meat like a wolf. Break it gradually, with thanksgiving, or you'll lose the spiritual profit."

"The day after a fast should find you closer to God than the day before—not just relieved it's over."

Oral tradition

Key Takeaway

"Fast with love for God, not fear of rules. The Church's fasting calendar is a medicine, not a punishment. Take the dose you can handle—but take it!"

"A humble fast of bread and water pleases God more than a strict fast of caviar and pride."